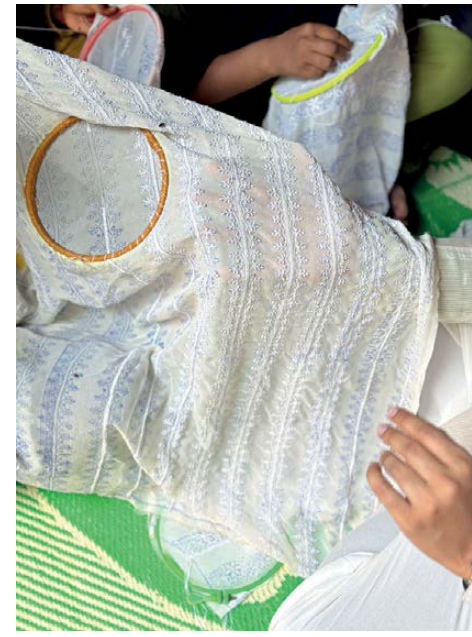


LEGACY

FASHION



FROM CRAFT TO COUTURE

Once patronised by India's royal families, several Indian art forms are being revived and kept alive by designers who serve as modern patrons. Here's a toast to the royal ateliers.

Riaan Jacob George



Anjul Bhandari's chikankari revival (Above) and Vipul Shah's patchwork bags (right) are at the centre of the discussion on Indian artisans

In one of Lucknow's oldest quarters, I walk through the labyrinthine streets in search of India's last few kamdaani artisans. Anjul Bhandari, a Delhi-based revivalist specialising in Chikankari and kamdaani artforms, leads me to a little workshop. From the outside, this workshop, looks basic, even rudimentary, but as soon as I step in, the space opens out to a craft cocoon where luxury is essentially being created every minute. A small group of men, huddled over beautiful fabrics, painstakingly carrying out the kamdaani work on each, before they're shipped off to create some of the most exquisite couture creations. I sit alongside a fourth-generation craftsman, Shahnawaz Abdulla, who explains the provenance of this exquisite art form that dates back to Nawabi times in Lucknow, and was